Hestia Construction

By almost any measure, Hestia Construction was thriving in 2019. Founder Rachel Street had been honored by *Philadelphia Magazine* and the *Philadelphia Inquirer*. Her construction projects and real estate listings were featured in local and national publications, including the *Wall Street Journal* and *Parade* magazine, which helped her reach a wide audience. Street was even recruited to host *Philly Revival*, a DIY show that followed her for six episodes as she remodeled neglected historic homes. The show put Street and her business on the map, attracting attention from clients and suppliers and opening doors to new opportunities.

By 2025, however, the organic marketing and grassroots branding that had fueled Street's success were no longer enough. Competitors were leveraging social media marketing in ways that she was not. While Street's reputation was strong, she worried that without a dedicated strategy, she might lose out on key projects to competitors who were investing in online ads, search engine optimization (SEO), and paid promotions.

Background

In 2008, a global recession prompted Street to return home to Philadelphia from Italy, leaving behind her career as an opera singer to work in her father's small commercial mortgage business—a business she knew little about. Over the years, Street mastered the loan and appraisal processes, earned her Pennsylvania real estate license, and renovated and rented out her first rowhouse.[1]

Before long, Street purchased a second house, basically an empty shell with four walls and no functioning kitchen or bathroom. When her father's commercial mortgage business closed after his death, Street sold her rowhouse for cash and found herself camping with her dog in the empty shell for months, showering at a nearby gym, while she painstakingly rebuilt the house piece by piece and discovered her niche.

"Once I finished that, I listed it for sale, and it got a lot of attention," Street said. "People started asking me to do their houses, so I thought, 'well, you should probably get a [contractor] license.'"

In 2015, Street launched Hestia Construction as an LLC specializing in full construction services and design-driven home remodeling. Her goals were twofold: to rehabilitate Philadelphia's neglected housing stock and to help the community by offering pro bono home repair and construction services for those in need. She also taught youth about skilled trades and participated in neighborhood cleanup efforts.

[1] Rowhouses, a popular housing style in Philadelphia, are narrow, two- to four-story buildings attached on both sides to neighboring houses.

Figure 1. Historic mansion restoration by Hestia Construction
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Street's commitment to historic restoration and attention to unique details, like decorative molding, original brickwork, and beveled glass, gained her a lot of attention (Figure 1). Many of her competitors, she said, were house flippers who bought undervalued properties at a discount, renovated them quickly, and sold them for a profit, but she wanted to honor the architectural history and unique features of each home—a goal she made clear when she met with potential customers.

Her reputation, built on word-of-mouth referrals and media coverage, earned her a roster of clientele and landed her a national platform with *Philly Revival*.

The Marketing Dilemma

Ten years into her business, Street knew things were changing in the market. She had never needed to buy media ads or send brochures to potential customers. Her online presence, reputation, and personal selling had always been enough. But organic reach on social media platforms—attracting customers without any paid promotion—was declining, and brands that weren't investing in digital marketing were struggling to stay visible (Hinson 2023).

Despite her success in building the business, Street had never considered herself a marketer—she didn't have to. She leaned into authentic storytelling, hands-on projects, and social-impact initiatives, all of which kept her name circulating in Philadelphia real estate circles.

She wasn't leveraging digital marketing, and she admitted that social media was not an interest of hers. "I have to be better at it, but I hate it," she said. "When I do put in the effort, I see results, but it's just not something I enjoy."

Even if she wanted to invest in digital marketing, Street faced another major challenge—time. She was deeply involved in every aspect of her business, from project design to client relations and managing contractors. That level of involvement ensured quality, but it also limited growth. Street was already stretched thin. She would need help.

Decision Time

Street stood in her office, staring at a proposal from a digital marketing agency. The plan was comprehensive—targeted ads, SEO optimization, content strategies—but it was a significant financial and strategic commitment.

She had three clear paths in front of her:

1. **Stick to the current plan.** Keep relying on word-of-mouth, community service, and local visibility. No major investment but potential missed opportunities.

2. **Start small.** Hire a freelancer or run a modest social media campaign to see how it goes before committing to a full marketing budget. Hiring a freelance social media manager to handle content creation and posting could cost $3,000–$6,000 per month. Running a small paid advertising campaign on platforms like Instagram and Facebook could start at $2,000–$5,000 per month. These options might not yield immediate results.

3. **Go all in.** Invest in a professional marketing strategy, recognizing that the construction industry is changing and digital visibility matters more than ever. A full-service digital marketing agency could easily cost over $8,000 per month, offering SEO, paid ads, and content strategy.

Each path had trade-offs. If she went all in, she risked spending thousands without a guaranteed return. If she did nothing, would her competitors leave her behind? And if she only made small adjustments, would it be enough to make a difference?

Which path should she take?

Rachel Street was interviewed in 2025 by a College Board case author for this case study.

References

Hinson, Frederick Ebo. 2023. Why your business will fail without a strong social media presence. LinkedIn Pulse. Retrieved April 10, 2025, from https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/why-your-business-fail-without-strong-social-media-hinson-acib/

